



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Olympians Rani, Sumit stress on all-round support for every sport

Former India women's hockey team captain Rani Rampal (centre) emphasised the need to support sports other than cricket during *Sportstar's* PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit in New Delhi.

"We respect every athlete and sport. But I honestly wonder if cricketers work harder than we do, since they receive more money and support.

"It's maybe because cricket has more visibility. Cricketers know that playing the Ranji Trophy can sort their careers. For us, even playing at the Olympics is not enough. Parents often say that *khel se roti nahi milegi* (sport won't earn you a living) to discourage kids from taking up sport.

"It's a hard fact," she said during the panel titled 'Athlete Economy and Influence: Nurturing India's

Olympic Movement'.

Two-time Paralympic gold medallist Sumit Antil stressed that financial support should reach athletes in their formative years, not only after medal wins.

"Before a medal, a para athlete struggles. I came to Target Olympics Podium Scheme in 2019. A prosthetic limb costs ₹4-5 lakh, and it can break during training.

"People wait for an NGO or support from somewhere, where they lose out on time and opportunities. There is plenty of scope for improvement," he said.

Offering a counterpoint, Neerav

Tomar (left), Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director of IOS Sports & Entertainment, spoke about how agencies have increasingly turned towards Olympic sports.

"Multiple agencies are behind Olympic stars. That's the change seen in the last two decades. Neeraj Chopra is now almost rubbing shoulders with the cricketers," Tomar said.

Tokyo Olympics silver-medallist weightlifter Mirabai Chanu (second right) also echoed the need for support that does not depend solely on sporting success.

"It is tough to qualify for Olympics and just be there. It's a big achievement for us, just to participate. At times, I feel I push myself too hard and get injured. When we win medals, we get praise. But the criticism is also severe when we don't win. This needs to change," Chanu said.

